Christianisation (or the creation of Christendom) was a cultural, political and also ‘technological’ and military process, a sort of globalisation of the early Middle Ages. The Western Roman Empire did not really care about it and disappeared; the Eastern Empire embraced it and survived much longer. The Roman (Western) legacy was taken over by the Franks, who did recognise the political value of Christianity, while the Eastern Empire took over some of the legacy of the ancient Greeks. Thus, in the early Middle Ages, the Frankish Empire and the Byzantine Empire each stood at its own end of the European continent, fighting to subdue – in a political and religious sense – the peoples in-between, above all the Slavs, who entered Europe about that time and who were to become central to what would be known as Eastern Europe.

What was at stake for these early ‘Eastern Europeans’ in this process? Of major political importance in the region at that time were two peoples: the Bulgars, i.e. the early Bulgarians (actually of non-Slav origin) and the Moravians (that is to say, the ancestors of the Czechs and the Slovaks), and both sought to manoeuvre between the two superpowers of the day, the Byzantine Empire and the Franks. Contrary to what geographical position might suggest, the Bulgars first sought Christian missionaries from the Franks, and the Moravians from Byzantium. The Bulgars’ approach to the Franks was not well received by the Byzantines and Constantinople reacted militarily. The final solution to what was, at first examination, a religious issue was reached at the ecumenical council in Constantinople where a majority of Eastern bishops decided that Bulgarians should fall under the religious rule of Constantinople rather than Rome. This left a profound mark on Bulgaria for the rest of its history: it acquired the Greek-influenced Cyrillic script and it remained in the realm of what later came to be known as Orthodox Christianity. The move also facilitated the Christianisation of Russians – the so-called Kiev Russians, i.e. the early ancestors of modern Russians and Ukrainians, who accepted Christianity in 987 AD. This lies at the roots of the preposterous Russian claims over Ukraine, which try to justify the recent aggression. In the now already infamous essay by Putin, *On the Historical Unity of Russians and Ukrainians* in July of 2021, seven months before the invasion, Putin claimed that Russians, Ukrainians and Belarus were one single people and that ‘true sovereignty of Ukraine is possible only in partnership with Russia’.[7]